# THE HOUSE OF IDEAS

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

## “HELLO, NEIL”

November 24, 2011 – May 21, 2012
Leimert Park • View Park • Beverly Hills • Hollywood • Los Feliz

An Alternate-History Hollywood Saga

**PROLOGUE: SEVEN MONTHS**

**INT. SIMONE SMILLEY'S APARTMENT - LEIMERT PARK - NIGHT (FLASHBACK)**

**SUPER: THURSDAY, NOVEMBER 24, 2011 - 6:30 P.M. PST - THANKSGIVING**

A small, warm apartment above a jazz club. Mismatched chairs, Christmas lights up a month early, a turkey Simone has clearly burned on one side. Around a folding table: SIMONE (32), CELESTE (51), CORNELIUS (78), HATTIE (76), ESTHER (29), and, in a sweater that his mother picked out, looking more nervous than he did at his first screen test, MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK (29).

Cornelius has been staring at him silently for a full minute. Marc-Anthony is holding a dinner roll he has forgotten to eat.

CORNELIUS
You're taller than you look on television.

MARC-ANTHONY
Thank you, sir. You're exactly as tall as you look in A RAISIN IN THE SUN.

CORNELIUS
(one eyebrow rising)
You've seen A RAISIN IN THE SUN? The 1959 production? There's no film of it.

MARC-ANTHONY
There's an audio recording at the UCLA library. I listened to it nine times last week. You do the second-act monologue slower than anyone ever has. It's the best version.

A long silence. Then Cornelius turns to Esther.

CORNELIUS
He did homework.

ESTHER
He always does homework, Granddaddy.

HATTIE
(passing the yams)
Victor's grandson doing homework on my husband. Lord, I've lived to see everything.

Laughter breaks the tension. Simone pours wine for everyone except Esther, who has been drinking sparkling cider all night. Celeste notices. Hattie notices. Cornelius notices last.

Esther looks at Marc-Anthony. He nods. She stands, holding her glass of cider.

ESTHER
I want to say something before the pie.

(deep breath)
Marc and I are... we're going to have a baby.

(beat)
Two babies. Twins. In June.

Absolute silence. Then Simone drops the gravy boat. Hattie puts both hands over her mouth. Celeste goes very still, then starts crying silently. Cornelius stares at his granddaughter.

SIMONE
(barely a whisper)
Twins.

ESTHER
Twelve weeks. We saw two heartbeats in October. We wanted to tell the people who'd be happy first.

She looks at her grandfather, terrified. Cornelius sets down his fork. He stands slowly with his cane, walks around the folding table, and stops in front of Marc-Anthony, who stands up immediately.

CORNELIUS
Do you love my granddaughter?

MARC-ANTHONY
More than anything in this world, sir.

CORNELIUS
Are you going to marry her?

MARC-ANTHONY
The day she says yes, sir. I've asked twice. She says she wants to do it right. Not because of a pregnancy test.

Cornelius looks at Esther. She nods, tears in her eyes. The old man turns back to Marc-Anthony and studies his face for a long time.

CORNELIUS
Your grandfather and I stood on a rooftop in Harlem in 1958 and promised each other our children would grow up together.

(beat, his voice thick)
It took fifty-three years and a generation too late. But I suppose great-grandchildren will do.

He opens his arms. Marc-Anthony hesitates, then steps into the old man's embrace. Hattie is sobbing. Celeste is laughing through tears. Simone picks up the gravy boat.

SIMONE
Well. That's the best Thanksgiving this family's had since 1966.

CUT TO:

**INT. SMILLEY ESTATE - DESMOND'S STUDY - VIEW PARK - NIGHT (FLASHBACK)**

**SUPER: SUNDAY, DECEMBER 4, 2011 - 8:00 P.M. PST**

Esther, fourteen weeks pregnant, the slightest curve visible under her sweater, stands in front of her father's desk. Celeste stands behind her. Cornelius sits in the corner.

Desmond (54) has just been told. He hasn't moved for a full minute.

DESMOND
(finally, flat)
Twins.

ESTHER
Twins. Due in June.

DESMOND
And the father.

ESTHER
You know who the father is, Daddy.

Desmond stands up. Walks to the window. His back is to the room.

DESMOND
Thirty years. Thirty years your mother and I built you. The good girl. The modern Shirley Temple. The one thing in this family that was never, ever touched by scandal.

(turning)
Unmarried. Pregnant. By Victor Donohue's grandson. The press will eat you alive. The church will turn its back. Every family movie, every faith audience...

ESTHER
I'm not making family movies anymore, Daddy. I'm Thor.

DESMOND
(his voice rising)
You're a SMILLEY.

ESTHER
(quiet, steady)
I'm both.

Silence. Desmond looks at Cornelius in the corner.

DESMOND
And you knew. At Thanksgiving. You all knew. And nobody told me.

CORNELIUS
We told you now, son. Face to face. That's more than Victor and I ever managed.

Desmond stares at all of them, his wife, his father, his daughter, as if he's standing on the other side of a glass wall. Then he speaks, very quietly.

DESMOND
Get out.

CELESTE
Desmond...

DESMOND
Please. Just... I need everyone to get out.

They leave. At the door, Esther stops and looks back at her father, alone at the window.

ESTHER
They're girls, Daddy. We found out last week. Two girls.

Desmond doesn't turn around. But his hand, at his side, closes into a fist and then slowly opens.

CUT TO:

**MONTAGE - DECEMBER 2011 TO MARCH 2012**

**PEOPLE.COM - EXCLUSIVE - MONDAY, DECEMBER 19, 2011**

**MARC-ANTHONY BULLOCK AND ESTHER SMILLEY EXPECTING TWINS!**

*"We've been best friends since we were eleven. We've been in love for a long time. We're so happy, and we're going to do this our way." The couple confirm their relationship for the first time and announce the birth of twins expected in June. "Hollywood's Romeo and Juliet" are going to be parents.*

**TMZ.COM - DECEMBER 19, 2011**

**DESMOND SMILLEY "DEVASTATED"? SOURCES SAY VIEW PARK PATRIARCH NOT SPEAKING TO DAUGHTER**

**THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER - DECEMBER 20, 2011**

**"SMILLEY-SAFE" NO MORE: HOW AMERICA'S SWEETHEART TORE UP HER OWN BRAND, AND WHY HOLLYWOOD IS CHEERING**

*Faith-based producers have quietly dropped Esther Smilley from two projects. Her Marvel contract, however, has never been safer. "She's Thor," says one executive. "Thor does what she wants."*

**TWITTER.COM - TRENDING (WORLDWIDE) - DECEMBER 19, 2011**

**amondbaker (9:02 AM)**
i am going to be an uncle. TWICE. i have known for 4 weeks and i didn't tell ANYONE. not even harmony. i am a new man. #StarkThorTwins

**harmonydivine (9:05 AM)**
@amondbaker you told me on week 2, babe

**amondbaker (9:06 AM)**
...i am mostly a new man

**priya_shah_phd (9:30 AM)**
in 2009 i asked esther smilley in hall h what she wants little girls to feel. now she's having two of them. i'm emotional in my lab again

**YOUTUBE - SUPER BOWL XLVI - SUNDAY, FEBRUARY 5, 2012**

**"THE AVENGERS" - OFFICIAL BIG GAME SPOT - 31,882,109 views in 72 hours**

*Top comment: "ten heroes. one shot of the camera circling them all. a hulk roar. a hammer. a shield. I'M NOT READY"*

**DEADLINE.COM - MONDAY, MARCH 26, 2012**

**'AVENGERS' TRACKING EXPLODES: RIVALS SAY $200M+ OPENING "ON THE TABLE"**

*Donohue's first Marvel release is tracking for the biggest opening in history. "The Dark Knight Rises" camp is reportedly "concerned."*

**PART ONE: THE PRESS TOUR**

**INT. FOUR SEASONS HOTEL - PRESS JUNKET SUITE - BEVERLY HILLS - DAY**

**SUPER: MONDAY, APRIL 9, 2012 - 2:15 P.M. PDT**

A hotel suite turned TV studio: lights, two chairs, an AVENGERS backdrop. An ENTERTAINMENT TONIGHT CORRESPONDENT (30s) sits across from MARC-ANTHONY (30), TYRESE AVERY (30), and AMOND BAKER (30), squeezed onto a loveseat meant for two. A speakerphone sits on the coffee table.

ET CORRESPONDENT
So, guys. What can you tell us about THE AVENGERS?

Marc-Anthony leans forward, completely serious.

MARC-ANTHONY
Honestly? The marketing has been very misleading.

ET CORRESPONDENT
...How so?

MARC-ANTHONY
It's not an action movie. It's three hours of the Avengers trying to decide where to go to brunch.

Tyrese doesn't miss a beat.

TYRESE
It's very tense. Cap wants a diner. Tony wants a place with valet. Hulk wants everything.

AMOND
(nodding solemnly)
Hulk does want everything.

MARC-ANTHONY
There's a twenty-minute scene where Thor orders all the pancakes. The entire menu. One by one. Esther refused to cut a single word.

He leans toward the speakerphone.

MARC-ANTHONY (CONT'D)
Isn't that right, Your Majesty?

ESTHER (V.O.)
(from the speaker, deadpan, lying in bed at home)
I ordered ALL of the pancakes, Marc. A god does not compromise on pancakes.

ET CORRESPONDENT
(laughing, confused)
Esther! You're on bed rest?

ESTHER (V.O.)
Thirty-two weeks with twins. My doctor said I can do press as long as I don't stand up, raise my voice, or lift a hammer. So this is a very relaxed Thor.

TYRESE
And in the big finale, Cap sings the specials.

(singing, in perfect pop falsetto)
"Eggs Benedict... with a side of freedooooom..."

The correspondent collapses with laughter. Amond, caught up in the moment, leans forward eagerly.

AMOND
And at the end, the Hulk walks away from the brunch, alone, because nobody trusts him, just like in AVENGERS #2, when he quits the team and...

Marc-Anthony and Tyrese both slap their hands over his mouth at the same time.

TYRESE
(calmly, to the camera)
He's thinking of a different movie.

AMOND
(muffled)
...mmph... different movie...

ESTHER (V.O.)
Amond, I'm on bed rest and I can still hear you spoiling things.

CUT TO:

**MTV.COM - SPLASH PAGE - APRIL 10, 2012**

**"AVENGERS: BRUNCH" IS THE BEST MOVIE THAT DOESN'T EXIST**

*Marc-Anthony Bullock's fake-movie routine has taken over the press tour. Over 40,000 fans have signed an online petition demanding Marvel make "Avengers: Brunch" as a DVD extra. Also: did Amond Baker just confirm the Hulk quits at the end? Fans are poring over the tape.*

**PART TWO: THE PREMIERE**

**EXT. EL CAPITAN THEATRE - HOLLYWOOD BOULEVARD - EVENING**

**SUPER: WEDNESDAY, APRIL 11, 2012 - 5:30 P.M. PDT - THE AVENGERS WORLD PREMIERE**

Hollywood Boulevard is closed for four blocks. Above the theater, the El Capitan's marquee is enormous: "MARVEL'S THE AVENGERS - WORLD PREMIERE." The Donohue logo and the Paramount logo sit side by side, exactly the same size.

A blue carpet, not red. In the forecourt: life-size practical replicas of every suit: the Mark VII armor, Cap's shield on a pedestal, Mjolnir on a stone, a giant Hulk fist bursting out of the ground. Ten thousand fans pack the streets. Helicopters circle overhead.

One by one, the Avengers arrive. TYRESE AVERY (30), in a navy tux with a tiny gold shield pin. AMOND BAKER (30), in green velvet, with HARMONY DIVINE (29) in black on his arm. They're "friends," as always. ARIANNA CUMMINGS (29) in purple. ELXA BULLOCK (31) and DAVID TIPTON (31). TOM HIDDLESTON (31) in a green-and-gold suit, bowing to the crowd. SAMUEL L. JACKSON (63) in an eyepatch, for fun. CLARK GREGG (50). JOSS WHEDON (47). STAN LEE (89), waving with both hands.

Then a hush. A black SUV pulls up to the curb. Marc-Anthony gets out first, in a charcoal tux. He turns. Offers his hand.

ESTHER SMILLEY (29) steps out carefully. Thirty-two weeks pregnant with twins, in a flowing midnight-blue gown that drapes over her belly, Cornelius's crown pin at her shoulder, a soft crimson wrap around her like a cape. A DOCTOR (50s) and a nurse in discreet black follow two steps behind.

The crowd goes absolutely insane. Ten thousand people screaming. "THOR! THOR! THOR!"

It's their first red carpet as a couple. Out loud. Not quietly anymore. Marc-Anthony keeps his arm around her waist. They walk slowly, stopping every few feet.

E! CORRESPONDENT
Esther! Marc-Anthony! Your first carpet as a couple! How do you feel?

ESTHER
Like I'm carrying the next generation of Avengers. Which I am. They kick every time somebody says "Hulk."

MARC-ANTHONY
We have to warn Amond to stop saying "Hulk."

E! CORRESPONDENT
And your doctor's here?

ESTHER
(gesturing behind her)
Dr. Patel gave me forty-five minutes. Fifteen for the carpet. Then I'm watching the movie from a private box with my feet up. Then home. She has a stopwatch.

DR. PATEL
(deadpan, holding up an actual stopwatch)
Eleven minutes left.

Laughter from the press line. A fan behind the barricade, a TEENAGE GIRL (14) in a homemade Thor costume, screams: "ESTHER! WHAT ARE THEIR NAMES?" Esther smiles and walks over to the barricade.

ESTHER
It's a secret. But I'll tell you one thing. They're both worthy.

The girl bursts into tears.

CUT TO:

**EXT. EL CAPITAN THEATRE - FORECOURT - CONTINUOUS**

**SUPER: WEDNESDAY, APRIL 11, 2012 - 5:52 P.M. PDT**

Two black cars pull up, one right after the other.

From the first: VICTOR DONOHUE (75) and JOAN (73), with NATASHA (50), ROBERT (53), and GRACE, who turns 18 tomorrow, in a sparkly dress.

From the second: CORNELIUS SMILLEY (78) and HATTIE (76), with CELESTE (52) and SIMONE (32).

The two families step onto the blue carpet at the same moment, about thirty feet apart. The photographers go completely silent for one second, then explode into the loudest burst of flashes of the night.

Last year, at THOR, there was a nod. Tonight, Victor Donohue lets go of his wife's arm and walks across the carpet. Slowly. Leaning on his cane. Straight toward Cornelius.

The press line holds its breath. Joan's hand goes to her mouth. Hattie grips Cornelius's elbow.

Victor stops in front of Cornelius. Two old men. A foot apart. For the first time since a courtroom in 1971.

VICTOR
(quietly)
Hello, Neil.

Cornelius goes completely still. Nobody has called him "Neil" in forty-one years. Nobody but the man in front of him ever did.

CORNELIUS
(hoarse)
Victor.

A long beat. A hundred cameras. Ten thousand people watching, most of them without understanding why it matters.

VICTOR
We're going to be great-grandfathers. To the same children.

CORNELIUS
I noticed.

VICTOR
Twins.

CORNELIUS
Girls. Esther told me at Thanksgiving.

(beat)
She told me before she told her father.

A flicker crosses Victor's face. He knows exactly what that means.

VICTOR
Neil. There are things I should have told you. In 1966. I tried to...

CORNELIUS
(raising a hand, gently)
Not on a carpet, Victor. Not with cameras.

(beat)
But maybe not never.

Victor nods slowly. For a moment, neither man moves. Then Victor holds out his hand. Cornelius looks at it. Looks at the cameras. Looks at his granddaughter across the carpet, eight months pregnant, watching him with tears in her eyes.

He takes Victor's hand.

It lasts two seconds. A handshake. Then both men turn and walk back to their families.

The press line DETONATES with flashes. On the far side of the carpet, Esther buries her face in Marc-Anthony's shoulder, sobbing. Dr. Patel looks at her stopwatch, then decides to pretend she hasn't seen it.

SIMONE
(to Celeste, stunned)
Mama. Did that just happen?

CELESTE
(tears running down her face)
It happened, baby.

CUT TO:

**TWITTER.COM - TRENDING (WORLDWIDE) - APRIL 11, 2012, 6:10 PM PDT**

**#TheHandshake - #AvengersPremiere - Victor Donohue - Cornelius Smilley - Hello Neil - #StarkThorTwins**

**INT. EL CAPITAN THEATRE - PRIVATE BOX - NIGHT**

**SUPER: WEDNESDAY, APRIL 11, 2012 - 7:00 P.M. PDT**

A velvet-curtained box overlooking the packed auditorium. Esther lies back in a reclining chair, feet up on an ottoman, a bottle of water in hand. Marc-Anthony sits beside her. Dr. Patel and the nurse sit at the back. Below them, a thousand guests settle into their seats.

ESTHER
Did my grandfather just shake your grandfather's hand?

MARC-ANTHONY
On a blue carpet. In front of ten thousand people.

ESTHER
(wiping her eyes)
Victor called him Neil. Nobody calls him Neil. Not even Grandmama.

The lights dim. The Marvel logo flips across the screen. A thousand people roar.

Esther takes Marc-Anthony's hand and puts it on her belly. Both babies are kicking.

ESTHER (CONT'D)
They know.

MARC-ANTHONY
They're Marvel fans already.

CUT TO:

**INT. EL CAPITAN THEATRE - AUDITORIUM - THE FILM - NIGHT**

**SUPER: WEDNESDAY, APRIL 11, 2012 - 7:00 P.M. TO 9:35 P.M. PDT**

Highlights, as the audience sees them:

-- Loki, with the Cosmic Cube in his scepter, tricks the Hulk into a rampage across a desert town, framing him for a disaster. The Hulk is hunted. The audience recognizes AVENGERS #1 panel for panel.

-- Thor descends from the sky in a storm to confront the "monster" she believes is Loki's weapon. Iron Man, Ant-Man and the Wasp, separately pursuing Loki, converge on the same spot.

-- The Hulk-versus-Thor battle on Park Avenue. Shot for real in front of Grand Central. The theater gasps when Thor's hammer meets the Hulk's fist and the shockwave blows out every window on the block.

-- The five heroes, battered and arguing, realize Loki has manipulated all of them. They stand side by side in the rubble. Janet van Dyne looks around at the strangest group of people she's ever seen.

ELXA (ON SCREEN, AS JANET)
We're going to need a name, you know. Something colorful. Something dramatic. Something like...

(beat, grinning)
...the Avengers.

The audience SCREAMS. Applause rolls through the theater for a full fifteen seconds.

-- Captain America, found in the Arctic ice, revived in a S.H.I.E.L.D. lab, waking up in 2012, staring at Times Square in total shock.

-- The final battle: Loki and his army in Midtown. All six heroes together in a single unbroken shot, the camera circling them as the city burns. Black Widow and Hawkeye fighting beside them on the ground. Thor calls down lightning. Iron Man flies through it. The Hulk roars. Cap raises the shield.

-- The end. Victory. The Avengers, a team now. But the Hulk turns and walks away alone, into the desert. Nobody trusts him. He doesn't trust himself. Exactly like AVENGERS #2.

The credits roll to a standing ovation that lasts four minutes.

CUT TO:

**INT. EL CAPITAN THEATRE - AUDITORIUM - THE POST-CREDITS SCENE - NIGHT**

**SUPER: WEDNESDAY, APRIL 11, 2012 - 9:42 P.M. PDT**

The credits end. Nobody has left. Not one person. The auditorium is dead silent.

On screen: deep space. A barren asteroid. A massive throne carved out of black rock, facing away from us. A hooded alien servant bows before it.

THE OTHER (ON SCREEN)
(a rasping voice)
The Asgardian failed, my lord. The humans have united. They call themselves the Avengers. Whoever moves against them now walks hand in hand with Death.

A long pause. The throne slowly turns.

THANOS. Massive. Purple-skinned. A scarred, ridged chin. Golden armor. Cold, ancient eyes. Played by JOSH BROLIN, his first appearance on screen, a secret kept for over a year.

He doesn't speak. He smiles, very slowly.

Then the camera pans. Standing beside the throne, so still nobody noticed her: a tall, gaunt figure in a flowing black hooded robe, her face pale and skull-like beneath the hood. MISTRESS DEATH. The embodiment of death itself.

Thanos looks up at her with something terrible and almost tender: devotion.

She doesn't look back at him.

And then the camera pulls back further, past the throne, to a stone pedestal behind it. Resting on it, empty, waiting, is a massive golden glove with six

empty settings across the knuckles.

THE INFINITY GAUNTLET.

Black. White letters fade in: "THE AVENGERS WILL RETURN."

Absolute silence.

One second. Two. Three.

Then the El Capitan EXPLODES in a sound unlike anything anyone in that room has ever heard at a movie. Not a cheer. A scream. A thousand people screaming at once. Grown men on their feet with their hands on their heads. Stan Lee standing up in the third row, pumping both fists in the air, shouting something nobody can hear.

In the private box, Esther grabs Marc-Anthony's arm.

ESTHER
(shouting over the noise)
WAS THAT THANOS?

MARC-ANTHONY
(shouting back, equally shocked)
I DIDN'T KNOW! THEY DIDN'T TELL ANY OF US!

ESTHER
THAT WAS DEATH! STANDING NEXT TO HIM! THAT'S THE INFINITY GAUNTLET!

MARC-ANTHONY
KEVIN DIDN'T TELL ANYBODY!

Down in the auditorium, Amond is standing on his seat, both arms raised. Tyrese has his hands over his mouth. Hiddleston is laughing hysterically. Elxa and David are hugging. Harmony is screaming at Arianna, who is screaming back. Samuel L. Jackson has taken off his eyepatch and is rubbing his eyes in disbelief.

Standing in the side aisle, KEVIN FEIGE (38) leans against the wall, arms crossed, a tiny, satisfied smile on his face. LENORA HAYES (47) stands beside him.

LENORA
(shouting over the noise)
You didn't tell the CAST?

FEIGE
I didn't tell anybody. Josh Brolin flew in on a Sunday in 2011. We shot it in one night on a closed stage with eight crew. The footage went into my safe. Not even Joss saw the final cut until last week.

LENORA
Kevin. Mistress Death. The Gauntlet. You just told the whole world where you're going for the next seven years.

FEIGE
(smiling, watching the screaming crowd)
The comics told them in 1991, Lenora. I just showed them the cover.

CUT TO:

**INT. EL CAPITAN THEATRE - LOBBY - LATER**

**SUPER: WEDNESDAY, APRIL 11, 2012 - 10:05 P.M. PDT**

The audience floods out, still stunned. Everyone is talking at once. In a quiet corner by a pillar, VICTOR (75) and CORNELIUS (78) stand together. Both families are a few feet away, pretending not to watch.

CORNELIUS
Thanos. And Death. And the Gauntlet.

VICTOR
I didn't understand a single thing that happened in that last minute, Neil.

CORNELIUS
(a short, real laugh)
Neither did I. But our great-granddaughter's mother is a god.

VICTOR
And their father flies.

A beat. Two old men laughing quietly by a pillar in a crowded lobby.

VICTOR (CONT'D)
Come to dinner, Neil. After the babies come. Just you and Hattie. Joan and me. I have something to show you. A letter. I've owed it to you for forty-five years.

Cornelius looks at him for a long time.

CORNELIUS
A letter.

VICTOR
It's in a safe-deposit box. Joan keeps the key. I wrote it on New Year's Eve, 1966.

Cornelius's face changes. He doesn't understand yet. But he understands enough.

CORNELIUS
(quietly)
After the babies come.

VICTOR
After the babies come.

CUT TO:

**PART THREE: THE WORLD LOSES ITS MIND**

**MONTAGE - THE INTERNET AND THE MIDNIGHT SHOWS**

**SUPER: THURSDAY, MAY 3, 2012 - 9:00 P.M. TO FRIDAY, MAY 4, 2012 - 3:00 A.M.**

A packed IMAX theater at the AMC Universal CityWalk. Every seat filled for the 12:01 a.m. show. In the front row, in matching homemade "THE WORTHY" T-shirts: GARY MORRIS (46), PRIYA SHAH (27, four days from defending her PhD dissertation), DARNELL JOHNSON (34), and TOMMY REYES (24).

The post-credits scene plays. Thanos turns. Death. The Gauntlet.

Priya screams so loudly the people behind her cover their ears. Gary falls to his knees in the aisle. Darnell grabs Tommy by both shoulders.

PRIYA
(screaming)
MISTRESS DEATH! THANOS IS IN LOVE WITH DEATH! THAT'S INFINITY GAUNTLET #1! 1991! STARLIN AND PEREZ! THEY'RE DOING THE INFINITY GAUNTLET!

GARY
(on his knees, shouting at the ceiling)
SIX GEMS! SIX EMPTY SETTINGS! THE COSMIC CUBE WAS JUST THE BEGINNING!

TOMMY
Wait. Wait. If Thanos wants the Gauntlet, he needs all six gems. That's... that's like six more movies. Seven years. They're planning SEVEN YEARS.

DARNELL
(stunned, quietly)
Kevin Feige is a madman. I love him.

**REDDIT.COM - r/marvelstudios - "THE POST-CREDITS SCENE. MEGATHREAD." - 41,227 comments**

**u/MadTitanFan (12:58 AM)**
I've been reading Marvel since 1985. I never in my life thought I'd see MISTRESS DEATH in a movie. Thanos doesn't want to rule the universe. He wants to win the heart of DEATH. That's the comic. That's the REAL comic. Nobody gets nerfed. Not even the motivation.

**u/GemCollector (1:04 AM)**
Six empty settings on the Gauntlet. Infinity GEMS, not stones. Soul, Mind, Power, Space, Reality, Time. The Cosmic Cube isn't even one of them. Marvel is setting up something MASSIVE.

**u/NoNerfsPlz (1:10 AM)**
I asked Kevin Feige in 2007 if they were making the Avengers. He told me to read Avengers #1. In 2010, he told me to read Avengers #16. Tonight he told the entire world to read Infinity Gauntlet. I've never been happier in my life.

**u/ShellHead1963 (1:30 AM)**
Apology #213. In 2006 I said Marvel couldn't make one good movie. Tonight they showed me the next seven years and I believed every second of it.

**u/hulk_doesnt_read (1:45 AM)**
the hulk walking away alone at the end. just like avengers #2. amond tried to spoil it on ET and the internet thought he was joking. HE WAS NOT JOKING

**YOUTUBE.COM - "AVENGERS POST CREDIT SCENE THEATER REACTION (THANOS!!!!!)" - uploaded by midnight_marvel_mania - 14,882,301 views in 4 days**

Description: listen to the theater at 0:31. a man screams "THAT'S DEATH" and then just starts crying. i've uploaded every marvel reaction since 2008. nothing has ever sounded like this.

**TWITTER.COM - TRENDING TOPICS (WORLDWIDE) - FRIDAY, MAY 4, 2012**

**#Thanos - Mistress Death - Infinity Gauntlet - #Avengers - Infinity Gems - Josh Brolin - #AvengersBrunch**

**TWITTER.COM - PUBLIC TIMELINE**

**marcanthonyb:** i want everyone to know that kevin feige hid thanos from the entire cast. we found out at the premiere like everyone else. i've been betrayed. i've never been happier 12:20 AM May 4th from Twitter for iPhone

**amondbaker:** for once in my life i couldn't have spoiled it even if i tried. NOBODY TOLD US. this is how it feels to be normal. it's terrifying 12:30 AM May 4th from Twitter for iPhone

**esthersmilley:** 35 weeks pregnant with twins and i still screamed so loud at the premiere my doctor checked my blood pressure. thanos. death. the gauntlet. i'm not okay. go see it. #Avengers 9:00 AM May 4th from Twitter for iPhone

**tyreseavery:** the avengers is in theaters. 8 years ago people said i couldn't act. today i'm captain america in the biggest movie in the world. never stop jumping on the grenade 10:00 AM May 4th from web

**priya_shah_phd:** thanos is in love with death and the gauntlet has six empty settings. my dissertation committee meets on monday. i will be thinking about nothing else 11:45 AM May 4th from Twitter for iPhone

**FACEBOOK - GROUP: "MARVEL IS MAKING THE AVENGERS (CONFIRMED BY NICK FURY)" - Renamed May 4, 2012: "THE AVENGERS ASSEMBLED. NOW: INFINITY." - 4,881,302 members**

**Wall post - Jordan K. (University of Michigan, '09; Chicago, IL):** In 2007 I made a chart in a dorm room. 4.8 million of you joined. It came true. Now I'm making a new one. INFINITY GAUNTLET: six gems, six movies, one Mad Titan. See you in 2019.

CUT TO:

**DEADLINE.COM - SATURDAY, MAY 5, 2012, 8:50 AM PT**

**AVENGERS ASSEMBLES $92.6M FRIDAY: BIGGEST SINGLE DAY IN HISTORY! WEEKEND HEADED FOR ALL-TIME RECORD**

Friday, including $18.9M from Thursday midnight shows. That's the biggest single day in box office history, beating the $91.1M opening day of "Harry Potter and the Deathly Hallows: Part 2." CinemaScore: A+. Rotten Tomatoes: 93%. Exit polls show 61% of the audience stayed for the post-credits scene and 34% said they would see the movie again THIS WEEKEND. Donohue's distribution team is "beside themselves."

CUT TO:

**INT. MARC-ANTHONY AND ESTHER'S HOUSE - BEDROOM - LOS FELIZ - DAY**

**SUPER: SUNDAY, MAY 6, 2012 - 10:30 A.M. PDT**

A bright bedroom transformed for bed rest: pillows everywhere, a pregnancy chart on the nightstand, two empty bassinets in the corner, already assembled (by Amond, badly; by Marc-Anthony, again, properly). ESTHER (29), thirty-five weeks and six days pregnant, is propped up in bed. MARC-ANTHONY (30) sits on the edge, his phone on speaker.

Around the bed, crammed into the room: AMOND, HARMONY, TAYIA, TYRESE, ARIANNA, ELXA, DAVID, GRACE (18), and SIMONE. Everyone has brought food. Nobody is eating. Everyone is staring at the phone.

FEIGE (V.O.)
Are you all sitting down?

AMOND
Grace is sitting on me again.

GRACE
He's still very comfortable.

FEIGE (V.O.)
Donohue's estimate for the weekend. Friday ninety-two point six. Saturday sixty-seven point four. Sunday estimated fifty-four point six.

DAVID
(instantly)
Two hundred and fourteen point six million.

FEIGE (V.O.)
Two hundred and fourteen point six million dollars. The biggest opening weekend in the history of motion pictures. Domestic. And six hundred and sixty-two million worldwide. In one week.

The room EXPLODES. Tayia screams. Tyrese and Amond lift each other off the ground. Harmony and Arianna hug. Elxa is crying. Grace is jumping on the end of the bed until Simone grabs her.

SIMONE
NOT ON THE BED! SHE'S CARRYING TWO AVENGERS!

FEIGE (V.O.)
Analysts are saying it's going to be the biggest movie of the year. Maybe the biggest movie of the decade. And Natasha just called me. She said, and I quote, "Tell my son the projectors are paid for."

Marc-Anthony laughs, wiping his eyes. He looks at Esther. She's smiling, both hands on her belly.

MARC-ANTHONY
Kevin. Thank you. For 2006. For all of it.

FEIGE (V.O.)
Thank you for the bagels. Now go have those babies. We start pre-production on THOR 2 in four months, and I need my god back.

Click. The room keeps celebrating. Esther tugs Marc-Anthony's sleeve.

ESTHER
(quietly, under the noise)
Marc.

MARC-ANTHONY
Yeah?

ESTHER
My father sent a text this morning. The first one since December.

She holds up her phone. Marc-Anthony reads it.

**TEXT MESSAGE - DADDY TO ESTHER**

SUN 5/6/12 7:02 AM

I saw it last night. Magic Johnson. Back row. 7:10. Where you sat in 2008. You were magnificent. I'm sorry I wasn't there. - D.

Marc-Anthony reads it twice. Then he looks at Esther. Her eyes are full.

MARC-ANTHONY
He sat in your seat.

ESTHER
He sat in my seat.

She takes a breath. And then, suddenly, she winces. A hand goes to her side. Marc-Anthony freezes.

MARC-ANTHONY
What? What is it?

ESTHER
(breathing, waiting)
...Nothing. Braxton Hicks. Dr. Patel said it happens.

(beat, smiling)
They just heard the box office. They're excited.

Marc-Anthony puts his hand on her belly. One of the babies kicks hard against his palm.

MARC-ANTHONY
(softly, to the belly)
Not yet, girls. Four more days. Let Mommy rest.

Across the room, Amond is leading everyone in a chant: "A-VEN-GERS! A-VEN-GERS!" Esther laughs and joins in, one hand on her belly, the other in Marc-Anthony's.

FADE OUT.

**MONDAY HEADLINES**

**SUPER: MONDAY, MAY 7, 2012**

**VARIETY - MON MAY 7, 2012**

**'AVENGERS' SMASHES ALL-TIME RECORD WITH $214.6M; $662M WORLDWIDE**

*Biggest opening in history crowns Marvel's 1963-faithful ensemble; Donohue's first Marvel release sets the bar for 2012. Analysts project $1.5 billion worldwide. Post-credits Thanos reveal "broke the internet."*

**THE HOLLYWOOD REPORTER - MON MAY 7, 2012**

**THE SIX-YEAR PLAN: HOW MARVEL BUILT THE BIGGEST MOVIE EVER, ONE PROMISE AT A TIME**

*"Nobody gets nerfed," Kevin Feige told fans in 2006. Six years, eight films and $214 million later, the industry is still trying to understand how a toy company above a car dealership changed Hollywood forever.*

**THE NEW YORK TIMES - ARTS - MON MAY 7, 2012**

**A Purple Titan, a Hooded Lady, and a Very Big Glove**

*The last 90 seconds of "The Avengers" are already the most discussed scene of the year. Comic book scholars explain why audiences screamed at a woman who doesn't speak.*

**ENTERTAINMENT WEEKLY - COVER (Issue of May 18, 2012)**

**THANOS IS COMING**

*Inside Marvel's best-kept secret: one night, eight crew, one safe, and a cast who found out at the premiere. Plus: "Hello, Neil." The handshake that ended a 41-year silence.*

**JET MAGAZINE - COVER STORY (Issue of May 21, 2012)**

**EARTH'S MIGHTIEST FAMILY**

*Eight Black heroes in the biggest movie of all time. Two great-grandfathers shake hands. And twins on the way any day now. Hollywood has never seen a week like this.*

FADE OUT.

**END OF CHAPTER FOURTEEN**